1 Film

In this unit you will find out:

- how films use narrative devices, such as flashback, and camera techniques to convey meaning
- how audiences classify films by recognising their genre characteristics
- how institutions and organisations promote and regulate films
- how women are represented in films and film posters.

TALKING POINT

- Start off with an instant survey. First each person should write down their two favourite and two least favourite films.
- Now combine your chosen films into two class lists. Do the same types of films – such as adventure, fantasy, science fiction, romantic comedy and Westerns – appear on both lists? Were the same types of films popular with both boys and girls?



Genre

Did you find that it was easy to say what types of films your favourites were? If so, it is because you already know a lot about **genre**. You can also probably tell, from a few seconds of a TV trailer or even from a poster, what genre a new film is likely to be, and you will have certain expectations as a result. What film genre do these three words suggest: *Saloon*, *Sheriff*, *Gunfight*? You probably thought 'Western' before you even read the second word! Media producers rely on your ability to recognise genre when they promote new films, to arouse interest, expectation and anticipation.

ACTIVITY 1

1 Work in pairs. Make a table like the one below to show the characteristics of four popular genres: Romantic comedy, Disney animation, Science fiction and Horror.

Genre	Typical setting	Typical characters	Typical plots	Typical props	Typical themes
Romantic comedy		Young man, young woman	They meet, hate each other, coincidences throw them together ...		

2 Now share your answers with another pair. Add any good ideas that you missed.

In film, exploring the ways in which **genre characteristics** are used to create style and appeal is very important. Films are often a complex mix of genres – known as *cross-genres* or *hybrid genres* – to attract the widest possible target **audience**. For example,

KEY TERMS

Audience people who are consuming a media text

Genre a type of media text with certain predictable characteristics

Genre characteristics or **conventions** the typical features in a text which show the audience what genre it is

Reading science-fiction films

Reading a film is similar to reading a book. First you must know the language, and then be able to work out what it means. Use this checklist to help you to look for the most important features in a sci-fi film:

- *Characters* (including aliens) will have clear roles and purposes in the narrative.
- *Costumes* are important – especially in future worlds.
- *Settings* are part of the created world and often involve **special effects**.
- *Colours* are important and are often symbolic, e.g. neon green often symbolises 'the alien'.
- *Soundtrack* is a vital clue to suggesting mood, theme and key moments.
- *Conventions* such as space, jargon, gadgets, weapons, etc. all build up the understanding of the narrative.
- *Special effects* may play a huge part – look out for animation, CGI (computer-generated imagery – see page 111), clever use of camera angles, action sequences.

KEY TERM

Special effects
exciting and dynamic visual or sound effects used to create impact in films

ACTIVITY 9

Practise your reading skills in science fiction. Watch clips from a range of sci-fi films. Make notes on the conventions, themes and characters as you go. Write your notes up as an essay or report.

ACTIVITY 10 EXTENSION

Prepare a more developed film brief (proposal), based around the following idea:

An exploration spaceship has gone missing without warning, and a crew must be sent to rescue them. Led by a female Captain and a male First Officer, the rescue ship is captured by an alien ship and taken to a new world where the inhabitants have very strange customs. The original exploration crew are also there, and the humans must work out a plan to escape and get back to Earth – but not without tragedy, love and an unexpected twist of fate before the end of the film.

1. Give your film a title and explain its meaning.
2. Cast the main parts and explain your choices.
3. Outline the narrative more fully, explaining all the interesting details.
4. Design the film poster.
5. If you are going to develop this work into a coursework piece, plan the promotion campaign for the film. This could include: storyboard or trailer, merchandise designs, soundtrack CD cover and DVD cover.



TIP

Keep your work from Activity 10 in your coursework folder.

You need to decide whether to do your Practical Production as part of a group of up to four or on your own. For some types of practical production, such as video-making, it is virtually impossible to work alone. For the other types, group work can be helpful: two or three views and sets of ideas are likely to make for a more interesting final product. You can find more details about working in a group in the introduction.

Writing an analysis and evaluation of your work

Another difference between your GCSE production and professionally produced material is that once the editor of *Smash Hits* has published the magazine, they do not have to write an account of how good they think it is. But you do!

The analysis and evaluation (also known as a *supporting account*, *written evaluative report* or *evaluative commentary*) form a very important part of the work you will do and of your marks (see the example on page 191). If you are working in a group, it is doubly important because it will show the individual contribution you made towards the work (see pages 10–11).

The written evaluation should fall within the word count limits given by your awarding body (see pages 10–11). It should include:

- A clear opening explanation of what you were intending to produce and the target audience at whom you aimed your production.
- Some evidence that you have thought about, and preferably researched, your target audience and the 'market' for your product.
- Your own comments on the decisions that were made at each stage of production and why those decisions were made. For example, if you had three video sequences of a particular section of your film and only chose one to include in the final edit – *why* were the other two rejected? These comments on the decision-making process will be very important for your teacher when the marks are being given because it shows how much you have learnt from doing the production work.
- In a group production, a clear account of all the things you were responsible for.
- Links between your product and professionally produced work of a similar nature. How and why is yours different?
- A final evaluation of the completed production, saying how successful you think it is, what you would change if you had the chance to do it again and a statement about what you have learnt as a result of the work.
- An appendix to your written piece which includes pre-production work such as storyboards, questionnaires, scripts and work schedules.

You should *not* include:

- A string of excuses about your teacher failing to give you the right camera/computer/battery.
- A minute-by-minute account of every button that was pushed and tripod that was carried – what examiners call the 'dear Diary' approach. You only have a limited number of words, not enough to waste describing unimportant details.

Research

An important part of pre-production is the research stage. Before you rush headlong into designing your advertising campaign or shooting your pop video, you will need to think about the content of your product and the audience you are aiming it at.

Any company launching a new teen magazine in the real world would first find out about the interests and needs of the teenagers they hope to persuade to buy their magazine. They would also analyse very carefully their target audience and the products already in the market.

For some types of product you may find it useful to do some market research. This need not necessarily take the form of detailed questionnaires – though that is a possibility. But you should at the very least try out any ideas you have on some representative sample of your target audience to gauge their reaction. You should then write up what you have learnt from the research in your analysis.

Another part of your research will probably have been covered during your GCSE Media Studies course. This is a study of the way in which media texts like yours are put together. In other words, you should be familiar with the *media language* you are about to use. An important part of producing a good practical production is the extent to which you have shown your teacher and the examiner that you understand and can use effectively the *codes* and *conventions* of your chosen medium.

What does this mean in practice? Suppose you are producing a radio magazine programme aimed at a teenage market about the latest film releases. If all you do is sit down in front of a tape recorder and talk in a monotone about a few films you have seen recently, you will not have used appropriate media language. A professional programme of this sort would include interviews, extracts of dialogue from some films, and a synopsis of what the films are about and who appears in them. The presentation would be slick, with no long pauses or 'ums' and 'errs'. Usually some sort of outline script guides the way the programme develops.

Choosing your medium

With your research completed, you now need to decide which type or types of media technology you are going to use to complete your production work. Ideally you will have tried your hand at a variety of print, audio and video projects during your course so you will know your own expertise and preferences. If not, it is important as part of pre-production to practise with the type of equipment you are going to use. If you start trying to shoot a video or record a radio programme for the first time during the production phase you are less likely to do yourself full justice.

Making a video

Video is arguably the most exciting technology to use for your practical work. It is really a multi-technology because you will be dealing with pictures, sounds and maybe graphic designs too.

For these reasons it is also the most complex. To get the best results you must be sure to plan every stage in the greatest possible detail. Because there are a number of different stages and activities involved in making a video production, it is a good choice for a group. Everyone will certainly have enough chance to make their own individual contribution.

One thing you should be clear about right from the outset: small is beautiful. A thirty-second advertisement can involve a tremendous amount of hard work and planning. It is better to think in terms of a short but highly crafted video than a ten- or fifteen-minute epic. The longer the video, the less attention is paid to getting each shot as tightly composed and appropriately edited as it ought to be.